

Checklist:

Performance Reviews

START EARLY: gather context and set goals

- ☐ Ask your manager what the team's goals are and how they connect to company goals.
- ☐ Ask what your manager personally cares about and what matters most to them.
- ☐ Talk with tenured teammates about what the company rewards.
- ☐ Listen to leadership priorities from all-hands, emails, presentations, or planning docs.
- ☐ Identify influential people involved in your review process.
- ☐ Understand what performance review system your company uses.
- ☐ Clarify who makes the final review decision.
- ☐ Clarify who gives input on your review.
- ☐ Find out when review decisions, calibration, and outcomes happen.
- ☐ Ask peers for advice on how to ensure a fair review.
- ☐ Set goals that support you, your team, your manager, and the company.
- ☐ Share goals with your manager and ask for feedback.
- ☐ Revise goals until your manager can support and endorse them.
- ☐ Record agreed-upon goals somewhere visible or official.
- ☐ Ask whether achieving your goals would meet or exceed expectations.

Build STRONG HABITS throughout the cycle

- ☐ Record wins weekly or biweekly.
- ☐ Capture completed projects, outcomes, metrics, screenshots, praise, and evidence.
- ☐ Keep a work log with notable work and impact.
- ☐ Hold regular 1:1s with your manager.
- ☐ Share progress, wins, challenges, and what is on your plate.
- ☐ Avoid assuming your manager already knows everything you are doing.
- ☐ Balance speed, quality, and meaningful impact.
- ☐ Build a reputation for getting important work done.

- ☐ Help teammates, your manager, and the company where appropriate.
- ☐ Track “glue work” and other helping work so it is visible.
- ☐ Watch for spending too much time helping others at the expense of core responsibilities.
- ☐ Ask for specific feedback well before review time.
- ☐ Seek feedback after meetings, incidents, presentations, projects, reviews, or new initiatives.
- ☐ Treat feedback seriously, but decide thoughtfully what to act on.

PREPARE before the review

- ☐ Assess whether your manager will be a strong advocate for you.
- ☐ Ask your manager how they think you are performing.
- ☐ Understand your standing relative to expectations and peers.
- ☐ Consider your manager’s level of trust, influence, and tenure.
- ☐ Identify review deadlines, calibration dates, and decision timelines.
- ☐ Give your manager important context before decisions are finalized.
- ☐ Gather peer feedback from people who know your work well.
- ☐ Write down positive feedback and growth feedback you receive.
- ☐ Create a self-review document.
- ☐ Include results delivered over time, not just recent work.
- ☐ Include qualitative examples such as helping others, mentoring, and judgment.
- ☐ Include original goals and outcomes.
- ☐ Include examples of competencies for your role or level.
- ☐ Include feedback from peers.
- ☐ Include praise and positive feedback.
- ☐ Decide whether to rate yourself in the self-review.
- ☐ Consider writing an honest self-assessment even if you do not assign a rating.

DURING and AFTER the review

- ☐ Remember the review is a snapshot, not your whole career.
- ☐ Set realistic expectations about ratings and outcomes.
- ☐ Avoid making major plans based on an uncertain bonus or rating.
- ☐ Be aware of common biases: recency, strictness, leniency, horns, halo, similarity, central tendency, and contrast.
- ☐ Consider whether your manager is skilled at giving feedback.
- ☐ Ask for specifics if feedback is vague.
- ☐ Reflect on negative feedback before deciding whether to act on it.

- ☐ Remember that you and your manager are ideally on the same side.
- ☐ Focus on long-term growth, relationships, skills, and impact.
- ☐ Keep the review in perspective within the larger arc of your career.